GRACIAS POR INVITAR, LIVING PROJECT PORTAL, SPRINT 1

Market Research

Five candidate problems, 51 customer interviews in two phases, and how the team narrowed to one.

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Summary

The team started Sprint 1 with five candidate problems and talked to 51 people about them across two phases. During Phase 1, 26 interviews were held across all five project candidates, but they were narrowed to two. In Phase 2, the team performed 25 interviews on the two selected candidate projects. The results showed that the nutrition candidate (that had looked strongest in Phase 1) did not hold up after applying it to a bigger sample of people, while the events candidate did. The team is moving forward with **Candidate 3: an event tracker that will inform people of what is happening in El Paso and Juárez before it happens.**

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1. Aggregating the Findings

Method note: interviews followed Mom Test rules.

1.1 Manual logging dies within weeks

This was the one finding that repeated across all the app candidates. In the finance conversations, people would stop logging their expenses after a month. In nutrition, all five Phase 1 participants had quit a tracking app within one to four weeks. In addition, 13 of the interviewed people in Phase 2 (for this same app candidate), four described quitting for similar reasons: forgotten snacks, or homemade food they couldn't estimate. The conclusion reached was that a product that needs the user to enter/track things every day eventually stops being utilized.

1.2 The information exists; it does not reach people

For events specifically, nobody said El Paso lacks things to do, but that they do not hear about them. Announcements are usually found on the Instagram pages of the venue, the organizer, or event/news accounts such as FitFam, and only reach people already following the right ones: "Unless you follow the exact business or page hosting it, you might never see it." People without social media, or who use it lightly, are cut off almost entirely.

1.3 Free resources exist already

For some of the app candidates, enough free alternatives exist, so we couldn't identify any market gaps that would make it worth it to introduce a new service doing the same thing; these needs were already being satisfied. For example, an interviewee mentioned that their credit card already categorizes purchases. Several Phase 2 nutrition participants find MyFitnessPal encouraging and sufficient. Similarly, the streaming problem is already served by JustWatch and Reelgood at no cost. Lastly, for the event tracker, regular Instagram users found no need for another event platform; however, we identified a gap for people who don't own any social media profiles.

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2. Top Pick: An Events Hub for El Paso/Juárez

Our assumption

People find it hard to find events and places to go to in El Paso/Juárez, often finding out after the events have already happened.

Phase 1 results

All six interview participants could name an event they had missed, which put the problem on the board. But only two of six said it happens often, and three said they do not look for events at all since they get the information through a social media feed or by word of mouth. When compared to Candidate 2's five-for-five Phase 1 result, this looked like the weaker survivor, and the team carried it into Phase 2 mainly because the missed-event stories were so specific.

Phase 2 results

The question set was focused on past experiences: the last public event attended and how they heard about it, where they look for details, the last time they found out too late and how often that happens, and one open question about what they would change. Twelve conversations, six with working professionals rather than students.

#	PARTICIPANT	HOW OFTEN THEY FIND OUT TOO LATE	WHAT THEY WOULD CHANGE
1	UTEP student, regular at markets/concerts	Once or twice a month	One place to see everything happening that weekend
2	College student who plans weekends with friends	"Pretty often"	Hearing about things at least a week ahead
3	UTEP student who goes out often	"Enough that I've noticed"	El Paso and Juárez together; discovery beyond the feed
4	Student with limited social media use	Every couple of months	Events by date, without needing Instagram
5	Student with a heavily curated Instagram feed	Rarely (weak signal)	Filtering by type of event
6	Software specialist	Could not say, "I'm not aware of them"	Tell it your interests, have it tell you what's on
7	Social worker	A few times a year	A standardized source
8	Attorney	A couple of times	Advertising beyond social media
9	County worker	Never because spouse finds events for them	No suggestion
10	Victim advocate	About once a year	A weekly round-up/calendar from official accounts
11	Paralegal	Rarely; follows enough accounts	One source; interest-based email digest
12	Aerospace engineer, regular event-goer	At least once a month	A central listing, like the weekly page that stopped

Six of twelve miss events they would have attended on a recurring basis (monthly, to a few times a year), four say rarely, and two gave no usable frequency.

Seven of twelve, in their own words and without being offered the idea, asked for a single place to see what is coming: "there isn't one place where I can just see everything happening that weekend"; "El Paso lacks a one-source location"; "there used to be a page that would put all of the events that were going on every week, but they stopped doing that." Three asked for interest-based filtering, two asked for about a week of lead time, and two asked for reach beyond social media.

Who is underserved?

- **Word-of-mouth dependents:** Of the twelve Phase 2 conversations, five describe someone else as their primary way of hearing about events, making this the largest of the three groups, though not a majority.
- **People with little or no social media:** Two Phase 2 participants and one Phase 1 participant had this issue. Google gives them "tourist attractions or places that are always open instead of actual events happening that weekend." They are the clearest gap but also outliers in some way.
- **People with a curated feed:** Even though they were able to find events easily, they still mentioned wanting to filter by interest.

Where people look today, and where this fails

CHANNEL	WHAT IT DOES WELL	WHERE IT FAILS, IN PARTICIPANTS' WORDS
Instagram / TikTok	Everything eventually gets posted	Only shows what you already follow; "keeps showing me the same type of stuff"
FitFam and similar accounts	One place many locals check	Still one account's curation; non-followers never see it
Facebook events	Notifies when friends are going	Limited to whoever posts there
Google	Finds details once you know the name	Returns places, not events: "doesn't show me what's actually happening"
Ticketmaster / artist accounts	Big shows	Only big shows, only if you follow the artist; tickets gone before you hear
Flyers, QR codes, road signs	Reach people offline	Localized to one coffee shop's wall or one road
A weekly listing page	Exactly what people asked for	It stopped or people aren't aware of the resource

What the evidence does not support

- **That everyone has this problem:** four of twelve Phase 2 participants rarely miss events, and the heavy Instagram users are satisfied. The pitch is for the underserved groups above, not everyone in El Paso, but eventually we hope that Instagram users would prefer the service too.
- **That Juárez is in scope:** We are not sure if Juárez would be included in the scope due to comments of people saying they don't care about events there; however, this could help us expand on the amount of users that would be interested.

- **That the sample is representative of the city's needs.**

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3. What Didn't Work / What We Pivoted From

App Candidate 1: Money already spoken for (dropped after Phase 1)

Three of the five participants had abandoned manual expense logging, but nobody described the stated problem of not knowing how much income was already being spent.

App Candidate 4: Market Master (dropped after Phase 1)

Every answer was a hypothetical, so we didn't have any real data based on facts.

App Candidate 5: Searching across streaming services (dropped after Phase 1)

The strongest evidence of any candidate since most participants had paid twice for something they already had access to. We dropped it anyway because we couldn't get availability data across five services as a student team, and JustWatch/Reelgood already solve this for free.

App Candidate 2: Eating toward a body goal (dropped after Phase 2)

The team recorded one limitation at the time: every participant had been recruited because they already tracked macros, so the sample could confirm the problem but could not disconfirm it. Phase 2 fixed the sample, and the problem did not survive it. Of thirteen participants, three had never or barely tracked, three tracked loosely, two long-term app users find MyFitnessPal encouraging and sufficient, and four had tracked and quit for the logging-burden reasons in Finding 1. Not one described the specific problem we were looking to address.

App Candidate 3: Event tracker (chosen project)

Enough people, independently and without being prompted, described the same problem and asked for the same fix. That's a big enough gap in the market to justify choosing Candidate 3 over the other four candidates.

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